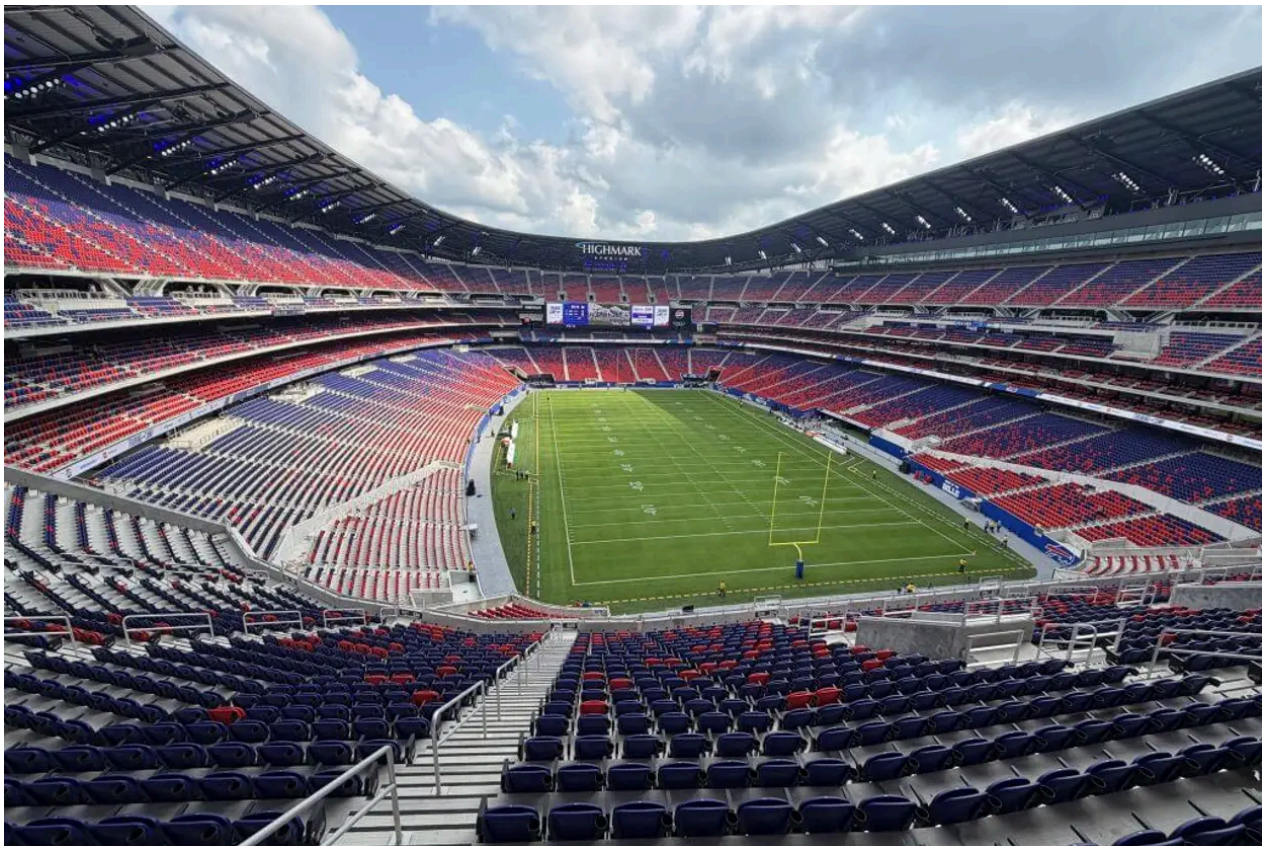


Bills respond to criticism over poor sight lines at new Highmark Stadium



Despite criticism over sight lines, the size of scoreboards and the stadium canopy, Bills executives told reporters Monday that early reviews of new Highmark Stadium have been "overwhelmingly positive." Joe Buscaglia / The Athletic



By **Adam Coleman** and **Tim Graham**

Aug. 11, 2026 | Updated 3:51 am GMT+3

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ORCHARD PARK, N.Y. — When a football stadium costs \$2.2 billion, with \$850 million from taxpayers, and the team mandates personal seat licenses for the first time in Buffalo sports history, a clear view of the field should be essential.

That wasn't the case when some Buffalo Bills fans arrived Saturday for Highmark Stadium's public unveiling.

The Bills say they've heard from only a minuscule number of season-ticket holders who were disappointed with their seats, though jarring images [spread across social media](#) after the Bills opened the new stadium to patrons for the first time at Saturday's Red & Blue practice. Fans posted photos of their sight lines blocked by railings, cable wires and stair landings. Some posted side-by-side pictures illustrating starkly different sight lines compared to what they were promised during the personal seat license sales process.

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Tim Graham and Madison Eades

While the controversy led evening newscasts around Buffalo, the Bills promised to address whatever issues they could but also stood by their sales methods as transparent.

“So far, we’ve heard from less than 1 percent of our PSL holders about anything sight line related,” Bills COO Pete Guelli said Monday on a conference call with reporters. “Relative to that specific issue, we feel very confident what was represented via the virtual venue is accurate to what people saw when they sat in their seats.

“If anybody feels otherwise, we’re taking this on a case-by-case basis, and we’ll address any concerns that they have.”

Given advancements in architecture, engineering and technology, it would be fair in 2026 to expect zero obstructed views in what should be — until the next one opens — the NFL’s showpiece stadium.

But all stadiums will compromise seating to accommodate design concepts.

“Any building you would walk into, there would be some obstructed seating,” Guelli said. “There are seats where we could create a different design, put in a blank area, or they give you the option to put in a seat that might be obstructed for football, but can be used for any other event like a concert. There’s always partial-view or limited-view seats, and we think those were pretty clearly depicted in our virtual venue.”

Guelli and Bills vice president of stadium development John Polka noted that some photos shared online were misleading. They showed seats that won't be sold for NFL games and will be "belted" to prevent fans from sitting in them. But those same seats might be viable for another event, such as a concert.

"Seats with truly obstructed views have not been sold as a PSL or for any football games," Polka said on Monday's call. "If we have a concert in the round at the 50-yard line or a stage in the north end zone, we may sell those tickets for an event, but not for football."

As for the images of sight lines blocked by fans and vendors constantly walking and gawking during the action, senior vice president of venue operations and fan experience Andy Major pointed out that Saturday night was a practice. The Bills will maintain a "wait-for-the-whistle" policy during games, with ushers holding back passersby until play stops.

The new Highmark Stadium was built on a 242-acre campus. Even at \$2.2 billion, not every inch — or every one of its 60,108 seats — will be flawless.

Other complaints from Saturday night's open practice focused on the size of the video scoreboards, poor stadium audio and a downpour that left sections of fans drenched, even though they paid to be under the canopy. Highmark Stadium's marketing materials boasted that nearly 65 percent of the seats would be covered.

"We're learning a lot about the building," Polka said, "and that includes game presentation. We'll look at how much of the scoreboard we're using for video versus using for content. We also have things in this building that we didn't have before. We have a nine-foot ribbon board right below that scoreboard that we may want to

use differently. But with the raw size of the scoreboards, we're comfortable and confident that those are the way we intended and designed them.

“From an audio perspective, it was a practice,” Polka added. “We had speakers down on the field that were for the players (to simulate crowd noise), but for a game, those speakers will not be on the field. There was competing sound in the bowl that our game presentation and audio teams were balancing out.”

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Many attendees were upset about traffic entering and leaving the stadium, but there's only so much the Bills can do to address that. It will take time for fans and law enforcement to learn best practices for so many new parking lots and traffic patterns.

Guelli said the punch list for odd jobs that need to be fixed or finished is about 27,000 items.

“It's 1.6 million square feet,” Guelli said, “and we've been saying from the beginning we'll be open on time to be functional and ready for football and our fans. But we'll

be working through a number of items for the rest of the season.

“It was an amazing, incredible night. The reaction that we got from the vast majority of the fans has been overwhelmingly positive. It’s a state-of-the-art, best-in-class facility. Nothing in that building compares to the old stadium, and I think, for the most part, people were blown away.”

Adam Coleman | Staff Editor, NFL

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